

Team Assignment – Organizational Change Analysis

In this assignment, your team is to talk to 20 people who have worked in organizations for at least 15 years. The more experienced, the better.

You will ask each person to describe the most successful organizational change they've witnessed and an unsuccessful one. The intent is to learn about changing how people are organized and interact with each other. This could include a reorganization, the introduction of new technology, a merger, that sort of thing. Unless it changes how people work together, something like a new product or marketing strategy is unlikely to provide much insight into organizational change. The more involved the person was in the organizational change, the better. You will, hopefully, collect 40 stories of organizational change (2 per person). You will look for similarities and differences in the stories, keep a count of things you think are interesting, and create one or more tables that display the data. You will analyze patterns across all the stories to identify similarities and differences, and cull insights into the roots of success and failure in changing an organization.

This assignment is worth 40% of your final grade.

It's expected that each team member will talk to 3-5 people, though each team can organize itself however they want. Each member doesn't need to talk to an equal number of people. Having these conversations in pairs is encouraged but not necessary. Each conversation will be written up in a standard format that your group devises, allowing for easy comparison.

It's assumed that most stories will be about different change efforts, but it's OK if a few (up to 3) interviewees talk about the same one.

A conversation guide has been provided for your use. You are strongly encouraged to develop additional questions that will yield unique data to differentiate your team's report and presentation from others'.

A final paper, authored by your team, is due at the end of the course. The final paper will include transcripts or notes from each conversation, including the date and the name (s) of the student(s) who held the conversation.

STIPULATIONS

Because you are conducting this inquiry as university members, I would like you to follow a couple of rules.

1. Each person you talk to must read or hear the informational overview that follows, and must verbally provide consent to discuss their experiences with you.
2. All write-ups and reports must disguise all names of people and organizations.

3. You can use artificial intelligence for your initial data analysis, and this must be presented in the format described later in this document. You cannot use AI (except Grammarly) to write the paper for you.

Grading Rubric

Report (5,000 words maximum)

10	Talk to the required number of people (lose 1 point for any less than 20)
30	Create useful and interesting data from those interviews, describing the initial AI results and how you rewrote those results to come up with your final analysis
15	Patterns of success and failure competently and comprehensively identified.
25	Clear and coherent explanations for HOW and WHY you produced the whittled-down set of key themes
20	Provide useful propositions, supported by evidence from the stories and logic from course materials and class discussions.

Structure of the Report

Maximum of 5,000 words, not including the appendix. Please use the three parts below as subheadings in your paper.

Part 1: Data

To use AI, you must follow and thoroughly document each of these steps to complete the assignment. I recommend using LUMO (<https://lumo.proton.me/u/2/>) with websearch turned off. That way, you can be assured that none of your interviews will be seen by anyone else.

1. To prepare to upload your interviews to an AI, if you have kept written notes, fill them in to the best of your memory. Add in whatever demographic data you have gathered to each interviewee's transcript. Essentially, you are creating a spreadsheet to allow the AI to compare across cases.
2. Strip out all names and give each interviewee a separate ID. This could be as simple as numbering each interviewee.
3. Separate out the part of the interview that is about successful change from the part of the interview that is about unsuccessful change.
4. Create two separate databases for successful and unsuccessful data, and ensure the AI doesn't access them simultaneously; otherwise, it will produce very confused results.
5. When you load the interview transcripts into the AI, make sure it knows each interview is separate and has an ID. Make sure these IDs are shown in the appended transcripts.

6. For the success interviews, ask the AI to identify 20 common themes from the data and provide 3 examples/quotes for each theme, identifying which interviewee each example came from. As you probably know, slight wording differences can produce very different results. Experiment with various prompts, and in your paper, provide the exact prompt that produced the results you worked with in the following steps.
7. Do the same for unsuccessful themes.
8. Provide a table with the final list of themes the AI created, along with the representative three quotes and the ID of the person quoted (this does not count toward your maximum word count)
9. Now, closely examine each analysis the AI generated and ensure that the examples it provides are actually in the data – this is where the AI is most likely to make stuff up. As a group, discuss these themes against what you learned from the interviews. You might want to conduct further analysis to determine whether factors such as size, organizational form, and other factors affect these themes. Identify which themes seemed true for at least half of your interviewees. Combine themes that seem to be about the same thing and rename them. Whittle it down to what you think are the most important. In your paper, discuss how and why you came to these common themes. For each of those themes, review your interview data and identify who said something consistent with that theme and the percentage of your sample that agreed with the theme. Prepare one or more tables showing each interviewee's ID and the theme they are associated with. For example:

Theme	%	Interviewees (N=20)
Theme 1	65	2,3,5,6,7, 8, 9, 10,12,14,15, 16 , 17, 18
Theme 2	60	1,3,5,6,7, 8, 9, 11,12,14,15, 16 , 19

Describe the information in the table(s). Never assume a Table or Figure speaks for itself.

Part 2 Patterns

Describe the patterns of success and failure you have abducted from your data.

Part 3 Propositions

Based on what you have learned, what do you advise leaders to do, and not do, to lead organizational change successfully? Here, you can go beyond your data, drawing on what you heard and read and your own experiences. **If you go beyond your data, you must explain why someone should believe those propositions.** What evidence or rationale supports your theories?

Appended

Transcripts or notes of the conversations, with all names disguised.

Informational Overview

As part of my MBA course, I will be asking you to describe two examples of organizational change you have experienced. When I write up this conversation, I will disguise your name and the names of everyone and every organization you mention. Other people in the course may hear your story or read my notes. Your story will be combined with more than 30 other stories my team is collecting to look for patterns in the success and failure of organizational change. The notes from our conversation will be part of the report my team prepares to complete our assignment.

There are no obvious risks to you, and you are free to stop participating at any time. If there is anything you say that you do not want in the interview report, just tell me. If there is anything about this you later have concerns about, you can contact my professor, Gervase Bushe, or the Dean of the Business School at SFU. Do you have any questions or concerns before we start?

Conversation Guide

1. I would like you to reflect on your career and identify the most successful organizational change you were ever part of. Later, I will ask you to describe an unsuccessful change. I'm particularly interested in changes to how an organization is organized to do the work, not so much in the introduction of a new product or advertising effort, or in the sort of thing that doesn't actually change how people interact and do their jobs.

Tell me about the change. What was the change intended to accomplish? What were the initial plans?

- Note if techno-structural, cultural, talent management, new business, merger, new strategy, etc.
- Note whether the change involved more of a technical problem or an adaptive challenge¹.

Tell me what you know about how the decision to attempt this change was made.

- Note whether they were in a position to know or are reporting their opinion.
- Note the extent to which stakeholders were involved in deciding on the change versus just senior leaders or external experts.
- Note the extent to which it was a reaction to a problem (how dire) versus a desire to improve or exploit an opportunity.

If you find that the interviewee does not have much information about the change in question, probe for another change in which they were more involved.

Describe the processes that were used to create change. What happened first, then what happened, and so on.

Did leaders monitor and adapt as the change progressed? If so, how did they get information?

¹ See three slides about the work of Ron Heifetz, middle of class 7.

- Note if there were any large deviations from initial plans (adaptations)

In your opinion, when the people in charge of this change wanted information, did they want objective facts or did they want to know where people stood?

What evidence are you using to judge that this was a successful change?

2. I would like you to reflect on your career and identify an unsuccessful organizational change you were part of. Do any unsuccessful organizational changes stand out as particularly noteworthy to you?

Tell me about the change. What was the change intended to accomplish? What were the initial plans?

- Note if techno-structural, cultural, talent management, new business, merger, new strategy, etc.
- Note whether more a technical problem or adaptive challenge

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Make sure to collect background information on each case (industry, public/private, approximate size, growing, shrinking, or stagnating), as these factors might emerge as significant in the patterns you find.